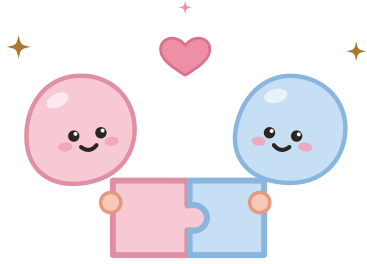
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · A POCKET GUIDE

The Logic Behind It

A Pocket Guide to Why People React the Way They Do



by Christian

Independently published
spreadloveandacceptance.com

The Logic Behind It: A *Pocket Guide to Why People React the Way They Do*. Part of the Spread Love & Acceptance series.
By Christian. Independently published.

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Not therapy. This guide is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counselor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation. No page labels anyone.

The examples are made up. The situations in this guide are drawn from common patterns, and nobody in them is a real person; any likeness is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the pages lean on is listed briefly at the back, and in full at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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How to use this guide

Thirty-eight everyday reactions, one to a page. Each page walks through the same six parts, so after a few you'll start to see the logic in reactions this guide never mentions.

- **Dip in anywhere.** Every page stands on its own. Use the contents, the section pages or "Find it fast" at the back to go straight to whatever's in front of you.
- **Read it with the other person.** A page can say what's hard to say in the moment. Hand it over, or read it together, and talk about the last two parts, the other side and the small step.
- **Use it both ways.** Some pages may explain you. Some may explain the people around you. Either way, the point is a fair view of both sides.
- **Scan for more.** Each page has a code to the same situation on the website, free, with more pictures to choose from. The website has more than seventy situations, and a box where you can type your own.
- **Build your own.** The blank cards at the back walk you through the six parts for a reaction this guide doesn't cover. There will be plenty of those.

THE SIX-PART LENS

Why a reaction can look odd

A friend leaves the party without saying goodbye. A colleague's feedback lands like a slap. Someone says "I'm fine" when they very obviously aren't. From outside, each of these can look odd, or rude, or a bit much, when it may be plain, direct speech or a tired body.

Most of them have a logic behind them. Once you can see it, it usually makes sense, given how someone is built, what they learned and what kind of day they've had. The trouble is that the logic is hidden, so the rest of us fill the gap with a guess. The guess is often unkind.

This guide puts the logic into words, a step at a time, and every page gives the other person's side as well, because otherwise it wouldn't be fair.

> **Why our own way looks normal** In the studies that named the false consensus effect, people overestimated how many others would make the same choice they had, and saw the other choice as the odd one. It's why a reaction unlike yours can look strange before it looks logical.
>
> **Ross, Greene and House (1977)** · *Strong: replicated many times, though the size of the effect varies*

No page is a diagnosis or a label. People differ, and no group always does anything. The pages say "many people" or "some people" on purpose.

THE SIX-PART LENS

The six parts

Take one reaction, yours or someone else's, and walk through six parts.

1. **What it looks like.** One line in camera words, what a camera would see or hear. There is no "rude" and no "weird," because a verdict closes the question before the logic can answer it. Describe what happened instead: plain words, a door closed, a reply that came late.
2. **The logic.** Three or four short steps, each following from the one before. The chain starts with a plain fact about how things work, such as "Energy works like a budget."
3. **It's like.** An everyday picture that works the same way inside. A phone on 3% shuts down the extras to protect the call, which is why it suits low energy so well.
4. **Why it fits.** What makes the reaction reasonable, said fairly and without stretching it. Where research supports a page, the research notes at the back list it.
5. **The other side.** What the other person may have felt or needed. This part keeps the lens fair, so nobody has to be the bad guy.
6. **One sentence and one step.** Words you could actually say out loud, and a step small enough to try this week that helps both people.

The order matters. Seeing the logic first makes the other side easier to hear, and the small step comes last, once both sides are on the table.

THE SIX-PART LENS

It runs both ways

Every situation carries one of three small tags.

COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE
a reaction many neurodivergent people have, explained for people who don't share it, such as headphones at dinner or a long talk about one interest.

A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT
a habit many people find natural, explained in plain logic for anyone who finds it baffling, such as small talk, "I'm fine" and hints.

SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO
a reaction anyone can have, such as snapping when hungry or going quiet in a row.

The tag says where a reaction is common. It never tells you what the person in front of you is.

> **The double empathy problem** The autistic researcher Damian Milton argued that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so the problem sits between them. His paper is an argument rather than an experiment; later studies support parts of it.
>
> **Milton (2012)** · *Theory: no data in the paper itself. Later experiments support parts of it*

The pages about common social habits matter as much as the others. If you have ever been told you "should have known" what

someone meant, it can be a relief to see that there was a system all along, and that it can be learned or simply asked about. And if you use those habits without thinking, seeing their logic written down shows where someone else might miss the signal.

The last section, “Different rulebooks,” is about habits learned in a particular place, family or generation. Two people can each be polite by their own rules and still upset each other.

THE SIX-PART LENS

Logic explains. It doesn't excuse.

Knowing why a reaction happened doesn't make its effects disappear. If a reaction hurts someone, the kind and logical next step is to say so, put it right and find a better step for next time.

Some pages have a line marked "With care." It appears where a reaction can land hard on someone else, and it says what keeps things fair.

Seeing the other side doesn't mean agreeing to everything the other person wants. A "no" or a limit given with care is part of looking after a relationship.

If you're reading a page with someone, start with the part about their side. People listen more easily once they feel understood.

SECTION 1

Plans and change

Last-minute changes, surprises, lateness, and what "sometime" means.

A plan does more than fix a time. For a lot of people it's a map of the day, already walked through in their head, and when it changes at short notice the map has to be redrawn on the spot. These pages are about what that costs, and about the friendly plans that were never really meant to happen at all. An economist would say the plan already spent some of the day's budget; changing it spends more.

1 Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute 11

2 Running late again, despite really caring 12

3 "Let's get coffee sometime" with no date 13

4 "Maybe" that means no 14



Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Ten to seven. "Oh, change of plan, we're meeting at the other place, and Jo's coming!" Mel says "Great." Then she says almost nothing for the next hour.

THE LOGIC

1. A plan is a map the mind has already walked
2. A late change means redrawing it, fast, with no warning
3. Redrawing burns the energy that was meant for the evening

IT'S LIKE

A *navigation app recalculating while you're already on the highway. For a moment it has no route at all.*

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, and for many anxious people, not knowing what comes next is costly in itself. A plan lowers that cost. Losing it at short notice is a real loss of something that was holding the day together.

THE OTHER SIDE

To the person who changed it, it was nothing much, maybe even a nice surprise. Now they feel their good idea has been treated like bad news.

> **"I'm not against the new plan. I just need a few minutes to catch up with the change."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Give changes as early as you can, with the reason. The person who needs time says "Give me ten minutes and I'll be on board," and then comes back on board.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=plan-changed

Running late again, despite really caring

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Twenty after, and here they are at the door with their coat half on and a breathless apology, for the third time this month. They plainly care, and they are also plainly late.

THE LOGIC

1. Some minds have two settings for time, "now" and "not now"
2. "Not now" turns into "now" all at once, with no warning in between
3. Getting ready takes longer than the guess said it would
4. So they're late, and they did care, both

IT'S LIKE

A *watch with only two settings, "plenty of time" and "too late."*

WHY IT FITS

For many people with ADHD, sensing time passing is genuinely harder. Researchers describe it as part of how attention and self-control work. It says nothing about how much someone cares.

THE OTHER SIDE

Waiting tells the waiting person they matter less, whatever was meant. It costs them real time, sometimes a cold dinner or a missed film, and over months it wears down trust.

> **"I misjudge time. You matter to me, and I'm working on it."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Set the alarm for leaving, not arriving, and text "Leaving now" as you go. Whoever's waiting can agree a time to start without you.
>
> WITH CARE Logic explains lateness; it doesn't make the other person's time free. A real fix (alarms, leaving earlier, a text) shows the care that the lateness hides.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=late-again

“Let’s get coffee sometime” with no date

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

“We should get coffee sometime!” Then nothing. No day, no text, for about five months.

THE LOGIC

1. It’s a friendly signal, not a booking
2. It means “I like you and I’m open to more”
3. A date would turn it into a promise neither of you has checked

IT’S LIKE

A *wave across the street. It means “hello, I see you,” not “come over.”*

WHY IT FITS

Many people use loose invitations to show warmth without putting anyone on the spot. Either person can turn it into a real plan later, or let it rest without anyone losing face.

THE OTHER SIDE

If you take words at face value, you heard a plan. You waited. When nothing came, it felt like a small promise broken, and you may not have said so.

> **“When I say we should get coffee sometime, I mean I’d like to. If you want a real date, ask me for one and I’ll say yes or no.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP If you want it to happen, ask “Shall we pick a day?” If you said “sometime” and don’t mean it yet, don’t worry. The other person can ask too.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=coffee-sometime

“Maybe” that means no

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

“Maybe. I’ll see how I feel.” Everyone else at the table seems to know that means no. You’ve kept a seat.

THE LOGIC

1. A flat “no” can feel like a door shut in someone’s face
2. “Maybe” lets the other person down slowly
3. Nobody gets refused out loud, so nobody loses face

IT’S LIKE

A *dimmer switch instead of a light switch. The light still goes off, just gently.*

WHY IT FITS

Indirect answers are a common way to say something awkward while keeping the relationship safe. Researchers describe this kind of speech as a way for both people to avoid an open refusal.

THE OTHER SIDE

For someone who takes words at face value, the question is still open. They keep a seat, wait for an answer, and later feel quietly misled.

> **“Sometimes I say maybe when I don’t want to hurt your feelings. I’ll try to give you a clear yes or no.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP It’s fair to ask, kindly, “Is that a maybe-yes or a maybe-no?” And honestly, a clear “No, but thank you” is kinder than it sounds.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=maybe-means-no

SECTION 2

Sensory and energy

Noise, touch, crowds, tiredness and hunger, and leaving early.

Noise, crowds, hunger and a long week all draw on the same supply. When it runs low, people leave early, or put their headphones in, or snap at a small question. These pages follow a battery running down, and what helps before it hits empty. Neurobiology's phrase for it is that your state sets the volume, and holistic practice, which has modest support, starts there, with the body.

5 Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye 16

6 Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people 17

7 Snapping when hungry or tired 18

8 Canceling plans after a long week 19

9 Needing time alone after seeing people 20



5 SENSORY AND ENERGY · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

You look around for Ross to say goodbye. Ross went forty minutes ago. There was, apparently, a wave from the door.

THE LOGIC

1. Energy is a budget
2. The party spent it faster than expected
3. Staying past zero risks a shutdown, or a sharp word to someone who didn't deserve it
4. Slipping out protects the evening and the friendship

IT'S LIKE

A phone on 3% that shuts everything down except the call you're on.

WHY IT FITS

A long goodbye costs energy too, with a round of hugs and small talk at the door. For people who find social time draining, including many autistic people, the quiet exit still leaves them able to get home safely.

THE OTHER SIDE

The host is left wondering if something went wrong. Friends aren't sure whether to text and ask, so mostly they don't.

> **"I had a good time. When my battery is gone I need to go quickly, before it runs out completely."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Send a short text afterward, such as "Thanks for tonight, I had to go when my battery ran out." Hosts can say up front, "Slip out whenever you need to."

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=left-party

6 SENSORY AND ENERGY · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Sunday lunch, nine people, the TV on and two conversations going at once, and one person at the end of the table has earbuds in with nothing playing through them at all.

THE LOGIC

1. Sound arrives whether you want it or not
2. A brain that filters less hears all of it at once
3. Headphones do the filtering, so there's attention left over for the people

IT'S LIKE

Sunglasses on a bright day. You still see everything, just without squinting.

WHY IT FITS

Many autistic people, and many people with ADHD or a sensitive nervous system, take in more of the background. Some researchers think this is partly about how much the brain predicts and smooths out what it hears. Turning the volume down can be what makes staying possible.

THE OTHER SIDE

From across the table it looks like a closed door. Most people won't knock on it, so they talk around the person instead, and the person notices.

> **"These help me stay at the table. Tap my arm and I'm all yours."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree a signal, a tap on the arm, that means "I'm talking to you." Where you can, turn the room down for everyone. One conversation at a time is kinder to more people than you'd think.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=headphones

Snapping when hungry or tired

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Six o'clock. Nothing since a cookie at eleven. "Have you seen the scissors?" gets a "No" that could cut them.

THE LOGIC

1. Patience runs on fuel
2. Hunger and tiredness drain the tank
3. On an empty tank, small things feel big
4. The snap is the fuel gauge talking

IT'S LIKE

A *car running on fumes, jerking at every junction.*

WHY IT FITS

Studies link poor sleep with more conflict between partners the next day, and suggest hunger can color how harshly we judge things, especially when we don't notice we're hungry. The snap is real information about the body's state.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person who asked about the scissors did nothing wrong, and they still got the sharp end. If it happens often enough, they start to tiptoe around you at dinnertime.

> **"I'm running on empty. It's not about you. Can we talk after I've eaten?"**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Name the state before you answer ("I'm wiped"), eat or rest, then come back and repair. Keep big topics away from the hungry, tired times of day.
>
> WITH CARE Explaining the snap doesn't undo it. A quick "Sorry I snapped, I was starving" after the snack is part of the logic working properly.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hungry-tired-snap

8 SENSORY AND ENERGY · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Canceling plans after a long week

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Friday, 4:52pm. “So sorry, I can’t do tonight.” The table’s booked for seven thirty.

THE LOGIC

1. Energy comes back with rest
2. This week used all of it up
3. Going out on empty means turning up in body only

IT’S LIKE

Pulling into the services when you’re too tired to drive safely.

WHY IT FITS

Rest is what makes good company possible. Sometimes the kindest thing a tired person can offer is a better evening later.

THE OTHER SIDE

The friend may have cleared their evening, booked the table or simply been looking forward to it. A late cancel can feel like coming last.

> **“I’m empty, not uninterested. Can we pick a new day now?”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Cancel as early as you can, and put a new date in the same message. If it keeps happening, make the plans lighter, a walk, say, or takeout on the couch where nobody has to put proper shoes on.
>
> WITH CARE Canceling often, or at the last minute, does cost the other person. Saying so and offering a real alternative keeps it fair.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=cancel-tired

9 SENSORY AND ENERGY · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Needing time alone after seeing people

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

The visitors' car is barely out of the driveway and he's already halfway up the stairs. The bedroom door shuts. Quietly, but it shuts.

THE LOGIC

1. Time with people can be lovely and still cost something
2. The cost has to be paid back
3. Quiet is how it gets paid
4. After it, he comes back down, and he's himself again

IT'S LIKE

Wringing out a sponge so it can hold water again.

WHY IT FITS

People recover from social time at different speeds. For many introverted people, many autistic people and many people who mask, quiet after company is how they recover, not a sign the company was bad.

THE OTHER SIDE

His partner wanted to go over the whole afternoon together, who said what about whose new kitchen. Now she's on her own with the dishes, wondering what she did.

> **"I had a good time. I need an hour on my own, then I'd love to hear what you thought."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree a recharge time after visits, with a time to come back together, such as a cup of tea together at eight.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=alone-after-people

SECTION 3

Talking and literal meaning

Blunt words, literal answers, hints, "I'm fine" and teasing.

The same words can carry a plain meaning and a hidden one. Some people say exactly what they mean and hear exactly what's said. Others hint, soften and tease, and expect the hidden meaning to be picked up. Both are systems. Either can be learned. Or you can just ask. Psychology's short version is that intent isn't impact.

10 Giving blunt, direct feedback 22

11 Saying "I'm fine" when you're not 23

12 Hinting instead of asking 24

13 Teasing as a sign of affection 25

14 Not looking at you while listening 26



10 TALKING AND LITERAL MEANING · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Giving blunt, direct feedback

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

You asked what she thought of your draft. She tells you. "The second half doesn't work." Period.

THE LOGIC

1. The aim is to help the work be right
2. Soft words can bury the point
3. A clear point is quicker to fix
4. Saying it straight is a way of respecting your time

IT'S LIKE

A *navigation app says "Turn left," not "You might like to consider left at some point."*

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, saying what they mean plainly is the honest, respectful option. Research on the "double empathy problem" suggests mix-ups between differently wired people run both ways, so the plain speaker isn't the only one missing signals.

THE OTHER SIDE

Words land on feelings as well as facts. If you spent two weeks on that second half, "it doesn't work" can sound a lot like "you don't work."

> **"I'm direct because I trust you with the real answer. I'm on your side."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Add one warm line before the fact, such as "There's a lot here I like." The listener can ask for it too. "Start with one thing that works, then tell me straight."
>
> WITH CARE If plain words keep hurting someone, the kind, logical move is to add the warm line, because the point lands better when the person isn't bracing.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=blunt

Saying “I’m fine” when you’re not

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A rough day is written all over his face, and every question gets the same two words. “I’m fine.”

THE LOGIC

1. Some feelings are too big to open in passing
2. “Fine” politely closes the lid for now
3. It protects the line, the meeting, the school drop-off
4. Often it means “not here, not now,” and leaves later open

IT’S LIKE

A “*Back in 10 minutes*” *sign on a shop door.*

WHY IT FITS

“Fine” is a widely understood way to keep a hard feeling private until there is time and space for it. It lets the day keep moving without lying about anything important later.

THE OTHER SIDE

People who take words at face value believe it, then get blamed for not noticing. Others feel shut out, or keep asking and seem nosy.

> **“When I say I’m fine, sometimes I mean I’m not ready to talk yet. I’ll try to tell you that instead.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Try swapping “fine” for “Not now. Later tonight?” And if you’re the one asking, “Now or later?” goes down better than “What’s wrong?”

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=im-fine

Hinting instead of asking

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"Bit chilly in here, isn't it?" Half an hour later Pat is quietly fuming because nobody shut the window.

THE LOGIC

1. A straight request can sound like an order
2. A hint offers the idea without any pressure
3. The other person can take it up as if it were their own idea, or not

IT'S LIKE

Leaving a door ajar rather than pushing someone through it.

WHY IT FITS

Researchers who study indirect speech argue that hints let people make requests while leaving everyone room to decline without embarrassment. It is a way of being polite.

THE OTHER SIDE

Hints get missed by lots of people, autistic or not. Then the hinter feels ignored, and somebody gets blamed for not doing a thing nobody actually asked for.

> **"When I hint, I'm trying to be gentle. I'll say what I need out loud."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Add the ask to the hint. "It's cold. Could you close the window?" The listener can check, "Would you like me to close it?"

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hints

Teasing as a sign of affection

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Two old friends calling each other terrible names across a bar table, both of them looking thoroughly delighted.

THE LOGIC

1. Teasing says "we're close enough to joke"
2. The insult works because both know it isn't true
3. Laughing together proves the closeness, again

IT'S LIKE

Puppies play-fighting. The teeth never close.

WHY IT FITS

In many friendships and families, gentle teasing is a ritual that shows trust. Both people know where the line is, and the joke reminds them they share that knowledge.

THE OTHER SIDE

Someone who takes words literally, or who was teased cruelly at school, may hear only the insult. It stings, and they may not feel able to say so.

> **"When I tease you, it's because I feel close to you. If it ever stings, tell me and I'll stop."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Check now and then. "Was that okay?" Agree what's off limits, and drop any joke that keeps landing as hurt, however good you think it is.
>
> WITH CARE Teasing that keeps hurting isn't working as affection, whatever was meant. The logical step is to stop that joke.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=teasing

14 TALKING AND LITERAL MEANING · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Not looking at you while listening

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

While you're talking, he looks at the table, or out of the window, or at his own hands, anywhere really except at you.

THE LOGIC

1. Eyes carry a huge amount of information
2. Reading a face and following words at the same time splits attention
3. Looking away frees attention for the words
4. So looking away can be how he listens harder

IT'S LIKE

Closing your eyes to hear the music better.

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, eye contact is uncomfortable or uses up the attention they need for listening. Studies find non-autistic people often judge autistic people quickly on style like this, even when what was said is just as good.

THE OTHER SIDE

Most of us were taught that eye contact means "I'm with you." Without it, it's very easy to feel ignored, or think they're bored, or hiding something.

> **"I'm listening. Looking away helps me hear you properly."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Check understanding with words instead of eyes, with the listener summing up one line of what they heard. Hard talks can happen side by side, on a walk or in the car.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=no-eye-contact

SECTION 4

Social rules

Small talk, white lies, "How are you?" sorry, goodbyes, and masking.

Small talk, white lies and "How are you?" can look pointless from outside. Each one does a quiet job, like showing goodwill or sparing a feeling. These pages set out those jobs plainly, along with what it costs to keep up appearances all day. The art of debating would add: say the other person's strongest point first.

15 Small talk about the weather 28

16 A white lie about a present 29

17 "How are you?" when nobody wants a full answer 30

18 A goodbye that takes half an hour 31

19 Fine all day, then falling apart at home 32



15 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

Small talk about the weather

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"Turned cold again." "Hasn't it." "Road work on the main street still." "I know." Five minutes of this, between two people who barely know each other.

THE LOGIC

1. Strangers need a safe way to check each other out
2. The weather has no risk in it at all
3. Swapping easy lines says "I'm friendly, you can relax"
4. Once both feel safe, real talk can start

IT'S LIKE

Musicians tuning up before the concert. There's no tune yet, but it makes the tune possible.

WHY IT FITS

Small talk isn't really about information. It's a way to show goodwill and build a little trust. Studies suggest brief, friendly chats, even with people we hardly know, are linked with feeling more connected and with better days.

THE OTHER SIDE

If you find it pointless or tiring, and many autistic people do, it costs energy and gives back no new information. Why is everyone so interested in rain?

> **"Small talk is how I say hello and check we're friendly. It doesn't have to be about the weather for long."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Keep two easy lines ready, and one real question ("What's keeping you busy at the moment?"). It's fine to steer toward something you care about after a minute or so.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=small-talk

16 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

A white lie about a present

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A sweater in a shade of orange nobody has ever worn on purpose. “Oh, I love it!”

THE LOGIC

1. The present is a message, and the message is “I thought of you”
2. The truth about the sweater would answer the wrong message
3. “I love it” answers the care, not the wool

IT’S LIKE

Praising a five-year-old’s drawing of you that is mostly a triangle.

WHY IT FITS

Many people see small, kind untruths as part of being warm. Studies find that lies told to spare someone’s feelings can actually make people trust the teller’s kindness more, though less so their honesty.

THE OTHER SIDE

If you value plain honesty, and many autistic people do, it simply feels like a lie. And then you start wondering what else isn’t true.

> **“When I say I love a present, I mean I love that you thought of me.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Find something true and kind to say, like “You remembered I like blue. Thank you.” Honest people can use this too, and nobody has to lie.

This one online

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=white-lie

17 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

“How are you?” when nobody wants a full answer

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

“You okay? How are you?” says a colleague, who is still walking, and is already most of the way down the corridor.

THE LOGIC

1. It’s a greeting that happens to be shaped like a question
2. Its job is to say “hello, I see you”
3. A short answer finishes the greeting

IT’S LIKE

A *nod across a busy room.*

WHY IT FITS

Lots of everyday phrases are rituals whose meaning is in the act, not the words. “How are you?” in passing works like a wave.

THE OTHER SIDE

A literal listener answers properly, with the hospital appointment and everything, and is left talking to the back of someone’s head. For anyone going through something hard, the ritual can feel very lonely.

> **“When I ask how you are in passing, I mean hello. If I really want to know, I’ll stop and ask.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Answer the ritual with the ritual. “Good, thanks, you?” Save the real answer for people who stop, sit down or ask twice.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=how-are-you

18 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

A goodbye that takes half an hour

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"Right, we'd better be off." Forty minutes later, everyone's still on the doorstep with their coats on, and the children are asleep in the car.

THE LOGIC

1. Leaving can feel like the end of the closeness
2. A slow goodbye winds it down gently
3. It's a soft landing for a good evening

IT'S LIKE

A *plane taxiing after it lands, rather than stopping dead on the runway.*

WHY IT FITS

Many families and friendships show warmth by stretching the goodbye. Leaving fast can feel abrupt to them, like the visit didn't matter.

THE OTHER SIDE

For someone whose energy ran out an hour ago, every minute on the doorstep costs, and there may be a long drive still to come.

> **"The long goodbye is my way of saying I loved this. I'll try to start it earlier."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Start the goodbye ten minutes earlier than you think you need to. Agree a family signal that means "It's time. Last bits now."

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=long-goodbye

19 SOCIAL RULES · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Fine all day, then falling apart at home

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Her teachers say she's an absolute delight. At 4:10 she slams the front door, and at twenty after she falls apart over being given the wrong cup.

THE LOGIC

1. Fitting in all day takes effort that doesn't show
2. The effort is held in until it's safe to stop
3. Home feels safe, so it lets go there
4. The crash is a sign home is trusted

IT'S LIKE

Swimming a length underwater and gasping at the far end.

WHY IT FITS

Research with autistic adults describes "camouflaging," working hard to appear like everyone else, often followed by exhaustion. Long stretches of it are linked with autistic burnout. Children and adults who aren't autistic can do a version of this too.

THE OTHER SIDE

The family gets the hardest hour of the day, every day, which feels unfair and baffling, especially when school sees none of it.

> **"I hold it together all day. Home is where I can finally stop."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Build in a quiet landing time after arriving home, with no questions for the first half hour. Tell school or work what home sees, so the load can be lightened there too.
>
> WITH CARE Falling apart at home can still land hard on the people there. Once settled, a few words like "that wasn't about you" help them carry it.



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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=mask-crash

SECTION 5

Work and school

Written instructions, "why?" deadlines, calls, meetings and feedback.

Deadlines, meetings and feedback come with unwritten rules, and people bring different ones into the same room. These pages are about asking for things in writing, starting late, agreeing in the meeting and disagreeing by the elevators, and wrapping criticism in praise. Business and politics agree that every job needs an owner and every group a fair way to decide.

20 Asking for instructions in writing 34

21 Doing everything at the last minute 35

22 Agreeing in the meeting, disagreeing afterward 36

23 Wrapping criticism in praise 37



20 WORK AND SCHOOL · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Asking for instructions in writing

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Ten-minute briefing, lots of nodding. At the end: "Sorry, could you put that in an email?"

THE LOGIC

1. Spoken words vanish as they're said
2. Holding them while you work splits your attention
3. Written steps can be checked again, and again

IT'S LIKE

A *recipe card rather than a cook calling instructions from the next room.*

WHY IT FITS

Many people with ADHD, many autistic people and many people with dyslexia find spoken instructions hard to hold while working. Executive functions like working memory differ a lot between people. Writing turns memory into something reliable.

THE OTHER SIDE

The manager may hear "I don't trust what you said," or just one more job at five o'clock.

> **"I ask for it in writing so I get it right first time. I trust what we agreed."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP After a chat, send a two-line summary. "So I'm doing X by Friday. Right?" The manager only has to reply "Yes."



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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=written-please

Doing everything at the last minute

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

The report had a month. It gets written between ten at night and two in the morning, with chips.

THE LOGIC

1. Interest and urgency switch the engine on
2. A deadline weeks away doesn't
3. When the deadline finally arrives, the engine starts
4. Late work is usually a starting problem, and the caring was there all along

IT'S LIKE

An old car that only starts on a downhill.

WHY IT FITS

For many people with ADHD, getting started depends on interest, novelty or urgency more than importance. Researchers link this to how motivation and self-control work in ADHD, and to attention and energy, so describe the late start rather than calling it laziness.

THE OTHER SIDE

Colleagues or family carry the stress of not knowing whether it'll be done, and sometimes end up quietly covering for it at nine the next morning.

> **"I care about this. My brain only starts when it's urgent, so I'm building in early deadlines."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Set fake earlier deadlines with someone else, work alongside someone (body doubling), or break the first step down to five minutes.
>
> WITH CARE When last-minute work pushes stress onto others, the fair move is an earlier check-in they can count on.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-minute

22 WORK AND SCHOOL · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

Agreeing in the meeting, disagreeing afterward

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Nods all the way through the meeting. Then, by the elevators, quietly: "Between you and me, I don't think it'll work."

THE LOGIC

1. Disagreeing in public can make people dig in
2. A quiet word later lets them change their mind without losing face
3. So the point gets through more often

IT'S LIKE

Telling someone privately there's spinach in their teeth, not announcing it.

WHY IT FITS

Many people raise disagreement privately because it's more likely to be heard. It protects the relationship and the other person's dignity.

THE OTHER SIDE

If you value saying things openly, it can look two-faced, and the meeting itself starts to feel like a bit of a performance.

> **"I raised it afterward so it would be heard. I wasn't going behind anyone's back."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Teams can offer both routes. "Say it now, or message me after." Quiet disagreers can say "I've a different view, I'll send it after."

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Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=disagree-later

23 WORK AND SCHOOL · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

Wrapping criticism in praise

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"Great energy! The whole report needs rewriting. Lovely formatting, though!"

THE LOGIC

1. Criticism on its own makes people defensive
2. Praise around it keeps ears open
3. Open ears take in the fix

IT'S LIKE

Hiding a tablet in a dog's dinner.

WHY IT FITS

Many people soften feedback to protect the relationship and keep the listener able to hear it.

THE OTHER SIDE

A literal listener may miss the middle entirely, or learn to distrust praise because it always seems to come before bad news.

> **"I meant the praise, and the change is important too."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Ask straight out, "What's the one thing I should change?" If you're giving it, say the fix clearly first, then one true good thing.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=feedback-sandwich

SECTION 6

Family and partners

Love shown in deeds, going quiet, chasing, reassurance and advice.

Close to home, a reaction lands harder, because it comes from someone who matters. Going quiet, asking again, giving advice nobody asked for. Each has a logic, and each has another side. Finance has a picture for it: a repair tops up a reserve of goodwill.

24 Showing love by doing, not saying 39

25 Going quiet in an argument 40

26 Asking for reassurance again and again 41

27 "If you loved me, you'd know what's wrong" 42

28 A parent giving advice nobody asked for 43



Showing love by doing, not saying

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Stan hardly ever says "I love you." He does fix the bike, fill the car and make the lunches from home at ten to seven every morning.

THE LOGIC

1. Love can be said or done
2. For some people, doing feels truer than saying
3. Fixing the bike is the message

IT'S LIKE

Two languages for the same sentence.

WHY IT FITS

People show care in different ways. Some, including many autistic people, find practical help a clearer and more honest way to show love than words.

THE OTHER SIDE

If you hear love mainly in words, you can feel unloved while surrounded by kind acts, which is a strange and lonely place to be.

> **"Fixing your bike was me saying I love you."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree one word and one deed. The doer says "I love you" on the way out, and the talker notices the deeds out loud.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=love-in-deeds

Going quiet in an argument

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Halfway through the fight he stops answering and looks at the floor, and somehow his saying nothing at all makes it worse.

THE LOGIC

1. A fast argument floods the body
2. A flooded brain can't find good words
3. Silence stops the bad ones getting out
4. Going quiet is braking, not punishment

IT'S LIKE

Pulling over in heavy rain until you can see the road again.

WHY IT FITS

Long-running research on couples found that arguments with more negative than positive moments went with more trouble later. Pausing when overwhelmed can stop a fight from turning more negative.

THE OTHER SIDE

Silence can feel like being shut out, or punished. If you're someone who needs to settle things before you can calm down, it can be frightening.

> **"I'm going quiet so I don't say something I don't mean. I'll come back."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Say a return time. "I need twenty minutes. I'll come back at eight." Then come back at eight.
>
> WITH CARE Silence with no return time can feel like being abandoned. Naming when you'll come back is what makes the pause fair.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=quiet-in-fight

Asking for reassurance again and again

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"Are you sure you're not annoyed with me?" It's the fourth time tonight, and you give the same answer you gave the other three times, a bit more tightly.

THE LOGIC

1. Doubt feels like danger
2. Reassurance switches the alarm off for a moment
3. The alarm comes back on
4. Asking again is trying to switch it off again

IT'S LIKE

Going back for the third time to check the front door is locked.

WHY IT FITS

Uncertainty can feel unbearable, especially with anxiety or with intrusive, repeating worries. Asking is an understandable way to get relief, even if the relief doesn't last.

THE OTHER SIDE

Answering the same question for the fourth time is tiring, and it can start to feel like your word isn't trusted. Answering it again and again can also keep the loop going, which is the unkind part of an act of kindness.

> **"I know you said it. My worry keeps coming back, and asking turns it down for a bit."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree a kind limit together. One clear answer, then "I said it, and I meant it," and something calming to do side by side.
>
> WITH CARE Endless reassurance can tire the other person out and keep the worry looping. A limit agreed together is kinder for both.

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=reassurance

27 FAMILY AND PARTNERS · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

“If you loved me, you’d know what’s wrong”

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Something is very clearly wrong. She won’t say what. What seems to hurt most is that he hasn’t guessed.

THE LOGIC

1. Being understood without asking feels like proof of love
2. Having to explain feels like it spoils the proof
3. So the hint stays a hint
4. It’s a hope, and nobody meant it as a trap

IT’S LIKE

Hoping someone notices your new haircut without being told.

WHY IT FITS

Feeling known is a deep need in close relationships. Wanting it shown without asking is very human.

THE OTHER SIDE

For a lot of people, autistic or not, mind-reading just isn’t available. The guesser feels tested, and set up to fail the test.

> **“I hoped you’d notice. I’ll tell you, and it still counts.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree that saying it out loud is allowed and still counts as being loved. The guesser can ask, “I can see something’s up. Tell me?”

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=you-should-know

28 FAMILY AND PARTNERS · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

A parent giving advice nobody asked for

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Three in the morning, you're finally getting the baby down, and your mother-in-law appears in the doorway. "In my day we just let them cry."

THE LOGIC

1. Advice is how some people show care
2. They learned things the hard way
3. Passing it on is trying to spare you that

IT'S LIKE

Someone pressing an umbrella on you as you leave.

WHY IT FITS

For many older relatives, passing on experience is their way of staying useful and close.

THE OTHER SIDE

At three in the morning "Have you tried…" sounds a lot like "You're doing it wrong."

> **"Thanks. I've got this, and I'll ask you when I need you."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Give them a real job they're good at, so their help has somewhere to go. Agree topics where you'd welcome advice.

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=unasked-advice

SECTION 7

Feelings and shutdowns

Meltdowns, shutdowns, a flat face, big reactions and needing space.

Big feelings can come out as a meltdown, a shutdown, a blank face or a fight about a mug. None of these is chosen in the moment. These pages are about what's going on inside, and what helps afterward. Music explains a lot of it, because tone and tempo carry more than words, and a shared laugh can reset a heavy room (the research on laughter is modest).

29 A meltdown 45

30 Shutting down and going still or silent 46

31 "I don't know how I feel" 47

32 Getting upset over something "small" 48



A meltdown

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Suddenly he's shouting, or crying, or running, and it looks far, far bigger than whatever just happened.

THE LOGIC

1. Input keeps coming, noise and demands and change
2. The brain's buffer fills up
3. When it overflows, control goes
4. A meltdown is an overflow, and nobody chooses it to get something

IT'S LIKE

A *bath overflowing because the faucet was never turned off.*

WHY IT FITS

Autistic young people describe meltdowns as different from tantrums. They come from overload rather than from wanting something, and they are not chosen. Children and adults can both have them.

THE OTHER SIDE

Frightening, if you're the one standing nearby. Embarrassing, if it's in a shop. And people very often feel it must be their fault, and don't know what to do with their hands.

> **"It was too much at once. I couldn't stop it, and I'm sorry it was scary."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP During one: fewer words, less noise, more space, and safety first. Afterward, rest. The calm talk about early signs can wait for another day, sometimes a week.
>
> WITH CARE Afterward, a repair and a plan for next time help both people.

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=meltdown

30 FEELINGS AND SHUTDOWNS · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Shutting down and going still or silent

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

She stops talking and stares at a point somewhere past your shoulder, and questions get nothing back at all.

THE LOGIC

1. Overload builds
2. The system switches off whatever isn't essential
3. Speech is often the first thing to go

IT'S LIKE

A *computer restarting in safe mode.*

WHY IT FITS

Autistic people describe shutdowns as an inward response to overload, where talking or moving becomes hard. It isn't sulking and it isn't a choice.

THE OTHER SIDE

People nearby can feel ignored or frightened, or sure they caused it, so they ask more questions. That usually makes it longer.

> **"When I go quiet like that, I can't talk yet. I'll come back."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Offer yes/no questions, a nod, or writing instead of talking. A quiet space and time help most.

This one online

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=shutdown

“I don’t know how I feel”

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

“How are you feeling about it?” “I don’t know.” And he really does seem stuck, not dodging.

THE LOGIC

1. Feelings start as signals in the body
2. Some people find those signals hard to read
3. No clear signal, no clear word
4. “I don’t know” is the honest answer

IT’S LIKE

A *radio caught between two stations, all hiss.*

WHY IT FITS

Researchers call difficulty naming feelings alexithymia. It’s common in autistic people, and plenty of others have it too. Feelings are linked to body signals, which some people read less clearly.

THE OTHER SIDE

It’s hard to be on the asking end. You can start to suspect something is being kept from you, when it may simply not have a name yet.

> **“I really don’t know yet. Ask me about my body. Am I tired, tense or hungry?”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Try simpler questions about the body. “More tired or more annoyed?” “Space or company?” Give it time and come back to it later, or tomorrow.

This one online

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=dont-know-feeling

Getting upset over something "small"

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

One mug, left on the counter, after a long, long day. And off she goes.

THE LOGIC

1. Stress builds up all day
2. Each thing fills the glass a little more
3. The mug is the last drop, and what spills is the whole glass

IT'S LIKE

The last drop of rain that makes the gutter overflow.

WHY IT FITS

Stress builds up and makes small things feel bigger. The reaction belongs to the whole day.

THE OTHER SIDE

Whoever left the mug gets the whole day poured over them. That feels unfair, because it is.

> **"It's not just the cup. It's been a heavy day, and that was the last drop."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Say "I'm nearly full today" early, before the mug. Afterward, apologize for the size of it, and talk about the mug another time, if it still matters.
>
> WITH CARE The person who did the small thing shouldn't carry the whole day. A repair afterward matters.



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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-straw

SECTION 8

Routines and special interests

Same food, my mug, long talks about an interest, stopping a task.

Sameness and deep interests are ways of saving energy and finding joy. From outside they can look rigid, or one-sided. These pages show the logic, and a way to meet in the middle. Behavioral science calls these habits that save effort; the setting matters too, and aromatherapy's modest point is that a familiar scent or a quieter room can help some people settle.

33 Eating the same food every day 50

34 Talking for a long time about one interest 51



Eating the same food every day

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Cheese sandwich, white bread, every lunchtime, for three years. Anything new is politely declined.

THE LOGIC

1. Every new food is a small gamble
2. A known food is a sure thing
3. Sure things save energy for the rest of the day

IT'S LIKE

A *favorite mug. Any mug holds tea; this one is right.*

WHY IT FITS

Taste, texture and smell are strong for some people, including many autistic people. A known food removes an unpleasant surprise and frees energy for other things.

THE OTHER SIDE

The cook has stood over a stove for an hour, so a polite "no thank you" can feel like the effort being refused. Families worry about health, too, and about every meal out.

> **"I eat this because it's safe and easy for me. It says nothing about your cooking."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Keep a "safe" option on the table next to anything new. Try new food on calm days, one small taste at a time, and no fuss either way.



This one online

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34 ROUTINES AND SPECIAL INTERESTS · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Talking for a long time about one interest

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

You asked one question about the 1950s train schedule. That was twenty minutes ago.

THE LOGIC

1. The interest is where they feel most themselves
2. Sharing it is sharing themselves
3. The detail is the gift
4. A long explanation is an invitation in

IT'S LIKE

Showing someone around your community garden plot, bed by bed.

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, special interests bring real joy and are linked with wellbeing. Sharing them is a way of connecting.

THE OTHER SIDE

Twenty minutes into the train tracks schedule the listener is lost, slightly trapped and far too polite to say either.

> **"When I go on about this, I'm sharing something I love with you. Tell me if you need a break."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Start with the five-minute version and ask "Want more?" If you're listening, "Tell me the best bit" works surprisingly well, and so does "Can we pause there and come back to it?"

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SECTION 9

Different rulebooks

Driving, tipping, "on time," loud families, plain feedback and texting: habits learned in different places.

A lot of friction comes from people following different rulebooks, each sure theirs is normal. What "seven o'clock" means. How loud a family dinner gets. How plainly feedback is given. Whether a period in a text is annoyed. All of it learned in a particular place, family or generation. Philosophy's habit helps here: separate the fact from the guess.

35 Different ideas of "on time" 53

36 A family that talks loudly and over each other 54

37 Feedback at work that sounds harsh, or too soft 55

38 Texting habits that seem cold or odd 56



35 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Different ideas of “on time”

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Dinner at seven. Bayo arrives at seven, on the dot, with wine. Shelley arrives at twenty to eight and thinks she’s on time.

THE LOGIC

1. “Seven o’clock” gets read through a local rule
2. In some families it means seven exactly, in others “from seven”
3. Each of them arrived at the time their rule calls polite

IT’S LIKE

A *recipe that says “a pinch,” when everyone’s pinch is different.*

WHY IT FITS

How strictly a time is kept varies between cultures, families, workplaces and kinds of event. A party, a dinner and a train each have different unwritten rules.

THE OTHER SIDE

The one who came at seven sharp sat with the wine going warm and the food going cold, wondering whether they mattered less.

> **“Where I grew up, seven meant come from seven. I’ll check what you mean next time.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Say which kind of time you mean, such as “Seven sharp, the table is booked” or “Any time after seven.”

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=on-time-means

36 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

A family that talks loudly and over each other

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Your first dinner at his family's. Everyone talking at once, at full volume, over each other. To you it sounds exactly like a fight.

THE LOGIC

1. Every family has its own volume, and its own rules for whose turn it is
2. In some homes, talking over each other means everyone's involved
3. Loud can mean warm
4. The noise is their normal, and nobody is fighting

IT'S LIKE

A *Saturday market, where the shouting is how business gets done.*

WHY IT FITS

Families and cultures differ in how loud and overlapping conversation is. In some, jumping in shows you're interested; in others, waiting your turn shows respect.

THE OTHER SIDE

Someone from a quieter home can sit through a whole dinner without getting a word in, and go home sure everyone was upset. By that family's standards it was a lovely evening.

> **"We're not arguing. This is just how my family talks."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP The quieter person can take short breaks, or ask a direct question to get a turn. The family can stop now and then and ask them in by name.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=loud-family

37 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Feedback at work that sounds harsh, or too soft

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

One new colleague says "This is wrong" in the meeting. Another says "Maybe we could think about it a bit more," and also means "This is wrong."

THE LOGIC

1. How directly people give feedback is learned
2. In some workplaces, plain words show respect
3. In others, softer words protect the relationship

IT'S LIKE

Two people using different units, miles and kilometers, for the same distance.

WHY IT FITS

Workplaces and cultures differ in how bluntly disagreement is expressed. Neither style is wrong, but mixing them without knowing causes a lot of hurt.

THE OTHER SIDE

The softer speaker can feel attacked. The plainer speaker can feel misled when the soft words turn out to have been hiding a real problem.

> **"Where I trained, we say it straight so it's quick to fix. Tell me if you'd like it gentler."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Ask early: "Do you like feedback straight, or with some cushioning?" Then agree a style for the team and write it down somewhere people will see it.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=direct-culture

38 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Texting habits that seem cold or odd

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Mom replies "OK." with a period, and her teenager reads pure fury. Meanwhile Grandpa has called, again, about something a text would have covered.

THE LOGIC

1. Texting habits are learned in a particular time and group
2. For some, a period just ends a sentence; for others it means annoyed
3. Phoning can mean care to one person and intrusion to another

IT'S LIKE

Handwriting, neat or scrawly. It says nothing about how they feel about you.

WHY IT FITS

Different age groups and friendship groups use punctuation, emojis and calls differently. The same message can carry different tones to different readers.

THE OTHER SIDE

"OK." with a period reads, to some people, like a door being shut. The writer usually meant nothing of the kind.

> **"My period isn't angry. It's just how I write."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Talk about it once, on a calm day. What does "OK." mean to each of you? When is a call welcome, and when would a text do?



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=text-generations

Build your own

For a reaction this guide doesn't cover, your own or someone else's. It works best on a calm day, and better still with the other person.

1. **What it looks like.** Camera words only. What would a camera see or hear?
2. **The logic.** Three or four steps. Start with a plain fact about how things work.
3. **It's like.** Something everyday that works the same way inside.
4. **Why it fits.** What makes it reasonable, said fairly.
5. **The other side.** What might the other person feel or need?
6. **One sentence and one step.** Words to say, and something small to try this week.

Watch for verdict words. "Rude," "lazy," "selfish" and "dramatic" are guesses about a person. A late start may be about attention or energy, and blunt words may be a plain, direct style. Swap the verdict for what a camera would see, describe what happened instead of the label, and the logic has room to show itself. If a step needs "because they're like that," keep asking why.

Online, it makes a card. The website's "Build your own" turns your six parts into a card you can save or share. Nothing you type is sent anywhere.

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

Find it fast

Every situation in this guide, A to Z.

A family that talks loudly and over each other 54

A goodbye that takes half an hour 31

A meltdown 45

A parent giving advice nobody asked for 43

A white lie about a present 29

Agreeing in the meeting, disagreeing afterward 36

Asking for instructions in writing 34

Asking for reassurance again and again 41

Canceling plans after a long week 19

Different ideas of “on time” 53

Doing everything at the last minute 35

Eating the same food every day 50

Feedback at work that sounds harsh, or too soft 55

Fine all day, then falling apart at home 32

Getting upset over something “small” 48

Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute 11

Giving blunt, direct feedback 22

Going quiet in an argument 40

Hinting instead of asking 24

“How are you?” when nobody wants a full answer 30

“I don’t know how I feel” 47

“If you loved me, you’d know what’s wrong” 42

Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye 16

"Let's get coffee sometime" with no date 13
"Maybe" that means no 14
Needing time alone after seeing people 20
Not looking at you while listening 26
Running late again, despite really caring 12
Saying "I'm fine" when you're not 23
Showing love by doing, not saying 39
Shutting down and going still or silent 46
Small talk about the weather 28
Snapping when hungry or tired 18
Talking for a long time about one interest 51
Teasing as a sign of affection 25
Texting habits that seem cold or odd 56
Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people 17
Wrapping criticism in praise 37

How the ideas connect

Many fields of study turn up in this guide, from music to economics, and underneath them the same seven roots keep showing through. Learn a root once and you can carry it from one field to the next: if a budget needs a safety margin, so does a tired person.

THE SEVEN ROOTS

Balance what flows in has to match what flows out

Signal and noise what's sent isn't always what arrives

Feedback loops small things repeated, with a check each time, shape the whole

Limited capacity everything has a limit

Ownership and structure work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one

Quiet incentives things drift toward whatever the setup quietly rewards

State and setting the same message lands differently depending on the state you're in and the place you're in

Neurobiology
Your state sets the volume.
In: Sensory and energy

Psychology
Intent isn't impact.
In: Talking and literal meaning

Philosophy
Separate the fact from the guess.
In: Different rulebooks

The art of debating
Separate the claim from the person.
In: Social rules

Politics
A fair way to decide, and a say for everyone.
In: Work and school

Behavioral science
Habits beat good intentions.
In: Routines and special interests

Economics
Attention is a budget.
In: Plans and change

Finance
Every entry has two sides.
In: Family and partners

Business
One owner per job, and a simple check.
In: Work and school

Holistic therapies
Start with the body, then the argument.
In: Sensory and energy

Laughter therapy
A shared laugh tells the body it's safe.
In: Feelings and shutdowns

Music
Tone and tempo carry more than the words.
In: Feelings and shutdowns

Aromatherapy

The setting matters.

In: Routines and special interests

Holistic therapies, laughter and aromatherapy appear only in their plain, everyday parts. The research on them is modest or still growing.

More, free online



The logic behind it

Scan with your phone's camera, or type the address.

`spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it`

- **More than seventy situations.** Every one in this guide, and many more, each with all six parts.
- **Find the logic.** Type what happened in your own words, and it shows the closest situations.
- **Another picture.** Most situations have two or three analogies; one of them may click where another doesn't.
- **Build your own.** Fill in the six parts and get a card to save or share.
- **The full guide.** How the lens works, the research behind it, and when logic isn't an excuse.

Everything is free, with no account. What you type stays on your own device.

Research notes

The 24 studies and essays these pages lean on, briefly, with the situations that use them. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found and how strong the finding is, is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Barkley, R. A. (1997). *Behavioral inhibition, sustained attention, and executive functions: Constructing a unifying theory of ADHD.* *Running late again, despite really caring* (12), *Asking for instructions in writing* (34), *Doing everything at the last minute* (35)

Boothby, E. J., Cooney, G., Sandstrom, G. M., & Clark, M. S. (2018). *The liking gap in conversations: Do people like us more than we think?* *Small talk about the weather* (28)

Craig, A. D. (2002). *How do you feel? Interoception: the sense of the physiological condition of the body.* *"I don't know how I feel"* (47)

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* *Giving blunt, direct feedback* (22)

Demetriou, E. A., Lampit, A., Quintana, D. S., et al. (2018). *Autism spectrum disorders: A meta-analysis of executive function.* *Asking for instructions in writing* (34)

Dunn, W. (1997). *The impact of sensory processing abilities on the daily lives of young children and their families: A conceptual model.* *Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people* (17)

Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014). *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* *Snapping when hungry or tired* (18)

Gottman, J. M., & Levenson, R. W. (1992). *Marital processes predictive of later dissolution: Behavior, physiology, and health.* *Going quiet in an argument* (40)

Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018). *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* *Talking for a long time about one interest* (51)

Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017). *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* *Fine all day, then falling apart at home* (32)

Jenkinson, R., Milne, E., & Thompson, A. (2020). *The relationship between intolerance of uncertainty and anxiety in autism: A systematic literature review and meta-analysis.* *Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute* (11)

Kinnaird, E., Stewart, C., & Tchanturia, K. (2019). *Investigating alexithymia in autism: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* *"I don't know how I feel"* (47)

Levine, E. E., & Schweitzer, M. E. (2015). *Prosocial lies: When deception breeds trust.* *A white lie about a present* (29)

MacCormack, J. K., & Lindquist, K. A. (2018). *Feeling hangry? When hunger is conceptualized as emotion.* *Snapping when hungry or tired* (18)

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem."* *Giving blunt, direct feedback* (22), *It runs both ways* (7)

Miserandino, C. (2003). *The spoon theory.* *Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye* (16)

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* *Talking for a long time about one interest* (51)

Pellicano, E., & Burr, D. (2012). *When the world becomes "too real": a Bayesian explanation of autistic perception.* *Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute* (11), *Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people* (17)

Phung, J., Penner, M., Pirlot, C., & Welch, C. (2021). *What I wish you knew: Insights on burnout, inertia, meltdown, and shutdown from autistic youth.* *A meltdown* (45), *Shutting down and going still or silent* (46)

Pinker, S., Nowak, M. A., & Lee, J. J. (2008). *The logic of indirect speech.* *"Let's get coffee sometime" with no date* (13), *"Maybe" that means no* (14), *Hinting instead of asking* (24)

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* *Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye* (16), *Needing time alone after seeing people* (20), *Fine all day, then falling apart at home* (32)

Ross, L., Greene, D., & House, P. (1977). *The "false consensus effect": An egocentric bias in social perception and attribution processes.* *Why a reaction can look odd* (5)

Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014). *Social interactions and well-being: The surprising power of weak ties.* *Small talk about the weather* (28)

Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017). *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* *Not looking at you while listening* (26)

The series

Spread Love & Acceptance is a series of short books. Each one stands on its own; read them in any order.

Book 1	**Know Yourself Kindly** Start with yourself: your history, your wiring, your feelings, your worth and how your mind works.
Book 2	**Heal and Steady** For the heavy days: stress, anger, worry and low mood, grief, repair, change and what matters to you.
Book 3	**Understanding Each Other** Pace and tone, how words land, how we see each other, belonging, love, groups and helping well.
Book 4	**Share the Load** For homes, families and teams: seeing the unseen work, one owner per job, and two kinds of fair.
Workbook	**The Workpapers: The Bound Edition** Every workpaper from the series in one bound book, with spare copies and the math on paper.
Pocket guide	**The Logic Behind It** *(this book)* Thirty-eight everyday reactions, one to a page, with the logic behind each one and a kind next step.

The print books are optional; everything stays free online at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

Your notes

Reactions you want to understand, words that worked, and steps to try.